Broken hand

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Overview

A broken hand occurs when one or more of the bones of your hand break or crack, often because of a fall. When falling, people reach out their hands to catch themselves. This movement is instinctive. This can lead to a break or crack, also called a fracture. A direct blow to the hand also may cause a break or crack. And a motor vehicle crash can cause hand bones to break, sometimes into many pieces. This type of injury often requires surgical repair.

Breaking a hand is more likely if you play certain sports, such as football or hockey. It also is more likely if you have a condition that makes bones weaker and easier to break, called osteoporosis.

A break or crack in one of the bones in the hand is called a metacarpal fracture.

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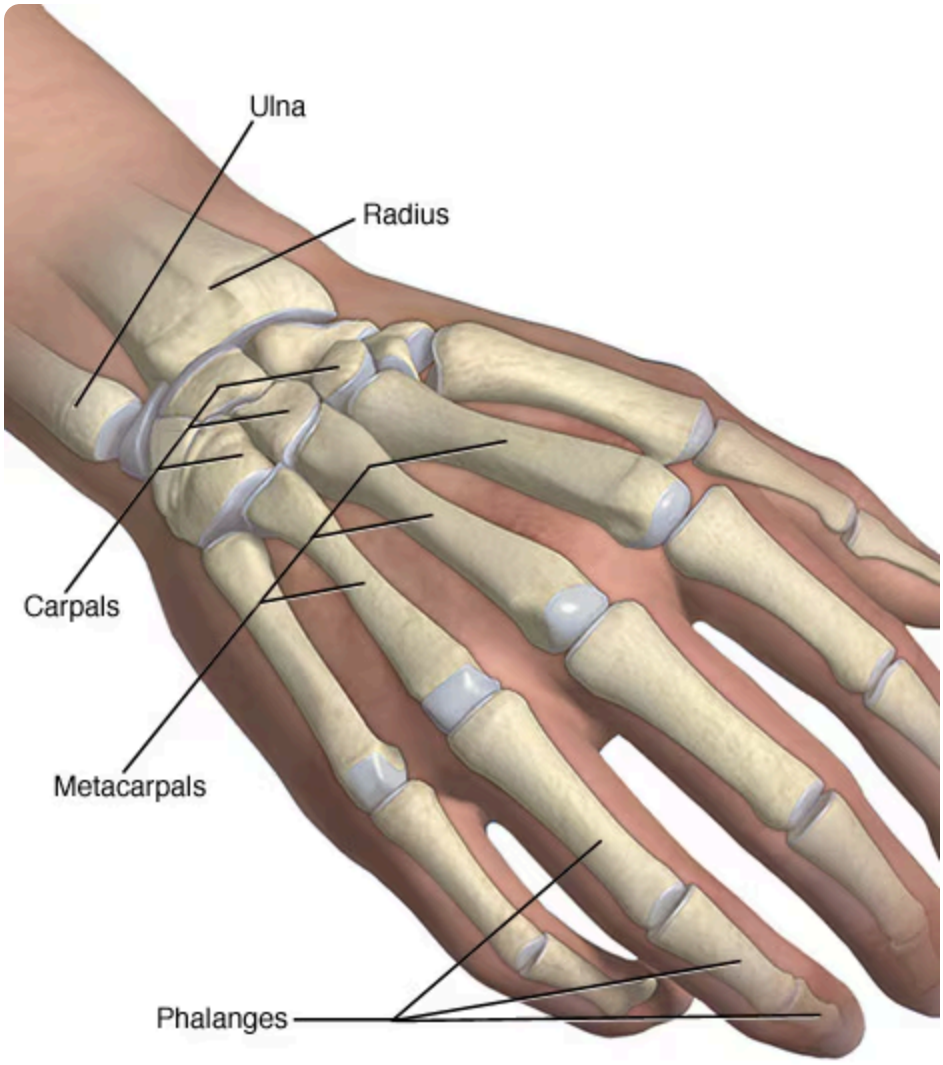
It's important to treat a broken hand right away. If not treated, the bones may not heal correctly. This makes everyday tasks, such as writing or buttoning a shirt, difficult. Early treatment also helps lessen pain and stiffness.



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Hand and wrist bones

Your hand is made up of bones called metacarpals and phalanges. Each finger consists of one hand bone, called a metacarpal bone, and three finger bones, called phalanges. The thumb consists of one metacarpal bone and two phalanges.

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Symptoms

Common symptoms of a broken hand include:

- Severe pain that may worsen when gripping or squeezing or moving your hand or wrist.
- Swelling.
- Tenderness.
- Bruising.
- Obvious deformity, such as a crooked finger.
- Stiffness or inability to move your fingers or thumb.
- Numbness in your hand or fingers.

When to call a doctor

If you think you might have a broken hand, see a healthcare professional right away. If you have numbness, swelling or trouble moving your fingers, seek medical care right away. Delaying diagnosis and treatment can lead to poor healing, reduced range of motion and weaker grip strength.

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Causes

A strong impact or crushing injury can break any of the bones in your hands. Common causes include:

- **Falls.** Falling on an outstretched hand is one of the most common causes of a broken hand.
- **Sports injuries.** Fractures often occur during contact sports or activities where falling on an outstretched hand is likely. These include activities such as pickleball, snowboarding and in-line skating.
- **Motor vehicle crashes.** Car crashes can cause severe fractures, sometimes breaking bones into multiple pieces and requiring surgery to repair.

Risk factors

Participating in certain sports increases your risk of breaking bones in a hand. Having a condition that weakens bones, called osteoporosis, also makes fractures more likely.

Complications

Complications of a broken hand are rare, but they include:

- **Ongoing stiffness, aching or limited movement.** While discomfort typically

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- **Osteoarthritis.** Fractures that extend into the joint can cause arthritis years later. If your hand starts to hurt or swells long after a break, contact your healthcare professional.
- **Nerve or blood vessel damage.** A hand injury can affect nearby nerves and blood vessels. If you have numbness, swelling or a change in the color of your skin, seek emergency medical care.

Prevention

You can't always prevent unexpected events that lead to a broken hand, but these tips may help reduce your risk.

Build bone strength
To build strong bones:

- Eat a nutritious diet with enough calcium and vitamin D.
- Get plenty of weight-bearing exercise, such as brisk walking.
- Quit smoking if you smoke.

Prevent falls
To help prevent falls:

- Wear sensible shoes.
- Remove things you can trip over in your home, such as throw rugs.
- Light up your living space.
- Have your vision checked and, if needed, corrected.
- Install grab bars in your bathroom.

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- Avoid slippery surfaces, if possible, such as walkways covered with snow or ice.

Request an appointment

By Mayo Clinic Staff

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